THEATRE

Nights of Love

Purva Naresh makes use of nautanki in *Chandni Raatein*, her musical adaptation of Fyodor Dostoevsky's short story *White Nights*





Photographs by NEVILLE SUKHIA

Call it serendipity or a dream come true, but a few years back, theatre writer-director Purva Naresh found herself reading a Hindi translation of Fyodor Dostoevsky's short story *White Nights* in St Petersburg, during white nights. Last year when Aadyam, an Aditya Birla initiative to promote theatre, came knocking on Purva's door seeking a pitch for a new play, she found herself returning to Dostoevsky's tragic romance. "I had seen the film [Luchino Visconti's 1957 classic] at FTII and I remember the entire batch came out crying. The melancholia, the way it strikes you, the monochromatic white nights, it was all so compelling," says Purva. "But I couldn't find any stage adaptations." In *Chandni Raatein*, Purva's take on the tale, she deploys music to underline the emotions and make it more affecting.

Chandni Raatein marks Purva's fourth collaboration with Aadyam after *Ladies Sangeet*, *Bandish 20-20,000HZ* and *Zoon*. "I can safely say that I was one of the first original scripts [*Ladies Sangeet*] that Aadyam green lit; one of the first woman directors to be brought on board and one of the youngest theatre groups," she says. Purva's group, Aarambh, has emerged as the go-to banner for staging musicals at Aadyam. "Music is within me, so stories will come through music," says Purva, who has trained in pakhawaj and kathak. In *Chandni Raatein*, she uses nautanki, a folk art form which she feels is closest to opera in its ability to sing the dialogue, as well as classical compositions and folk songs. Kaizad Gherda has composed the music.

Through the play, she hopes to explore what Dostoevsky tells us about love. So much so that the play's first line goes "*Yeh pyaar kya hai* [What is love]?" "It can be cheesy but it's also the most honest thing one can say," she says. "Love can make you lonelier, *bheed mein bhi akele* [alone even in a crowd] and still feel complete." The 170-year-old short story may not resonate with all but, for Purva, it has facets that are relevant even today.

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The play comes during the 15th anniversary of Aarambh. Having dabbled in films and television, it's on stage that Purva found wings. It helped that it was more economical compared to other mediums. "Any medium that will give you money to tell a story will demand you to tell it so as to earn it back," she says. "Theatre not only allows you to tell stories which are out of the box and you really want to tell, it's also not a capital-based industry. That's why audiences go to the theatre to hear stories that are different from the mainstream." ■

–Suhani Singh

You can catch *Chandni Raatein (left)* at **Nehru Centre Auditorium, Mumbai** (Feb. 15 and 16) and at **Kamani Auditorium, Delhi** (Mar. 1 and 2)